

Pradesh, echoes the point. "We wanted our name to be identified with a very-well known and respected brand."

The reason for this healthy respect is simple: All NGOs have to comply with strict norms and regulations to be included on the Web site. For instance, one selection criterion is that no NGO with a political link is allowed to be on the site. The rules also state that at least half the people benefiting from their projects should be economically underprivileged.

GiveIndia also does an appraisal of the organisation to see whether they meet Credibility Alliance norms. Credibility Alliance is a worldwide association of organisations and networks that aim to improve governance in the voluntary sector.

The last step, but probably the most important is when the GiveIndia team visit the NGO and see their activities themselves. It is not easy to qualify to be featured on GiveIndia.org. Apnalaya, for instance, found it tough to get in, even if its list of donors includes celebrities, such as, cricketer Sachin Tendulkar.

Says Joshi, who founded Apnalaya in 1979, "Qualifying to be registered with GiveIndia was not an easy process. But we felt it was good to get ourselves evaluated by an outside agency. The evaluation process helped us take a second look at ourselves."

The response has been tremendous, says Venkat. For instance, organisations such as Child Aid Foundation, Vijayawada, manage to get Rs 2-3 lakh through GiveIndia. "That's 50 to 60 percent of its annual budget. However, the same amount translated to just 25 to 30 per cent of the finances for organisations such as the National Association For The Blind."

Donorspeak

What can I donate?

Just about anything, and in any manner. Apnalaya, for instance, lets you contribute to its Corpus fund, General Fund as well as donate educational sponsorship for a child. Other projects range from programs that train a group of 25 in tailoring to three-day training programmes in community development. NASEOH specifies donations required for a tricycle, as well vocational training for a year for a disabled individual.

The mode of payment can be through a cheque, a demand draft, as well as online credit payment. You can also opt for ICICI's online banking payment system. GiveIndia also has a proprietary My Account system, wherein you can open a charity account with GiveIndia.org. You can deposit money in it via credit card, Net banking or cheque payments. You can get the requisite donation amount deducted from My Account.

If you do not like to donate, you can also shop and help by tying up with Craftsbridge, a company that promotes



Online donations help these children at Apnalaya get an education

Indian handicrafts. These funds are then used to support artisans who crafted them.

Can I donate my time?

Of course you can. If you like to spend your weekends or other holidays doing constructive work, you can register online to work in orphanages, old-age homes, helplines, schools, relief efforts, NGOs, etc. The Placement Services link has just about all the information you need to register at the nearest NGO.

I am an NRI. I used to donate for charitable causes while I was on vacation in India. It used to be so hectic. Then I found GiveIndia.org. I have been a regular donor through this site, and have been impressed by the way they provide a link between the donor and the NGO.

Sanjay Khanna

On the other hand, Apnalaya's 2001 earnings were Rs 40 lakh, as listed on the site. But since its online launch on GiveIndia, Apnalaya has been earning a small amount of its funds through this channel. "Online donations are sporadic in nature," says Joshi. "Many of them are one-off instances."

NASEOH's Balachandra says: "There is no uniformity in the nature of donations."

Adds Armine Damodiwala, head, Indian Council for Mental Hygiene (ICMH): "They are neither a huge flood nor a trickle. They ride on a medium wave."

Most contributions usually come in to sponsor individuals. Apnalaya found that projects such as community clinics that involve getting doctors to perform routine checkups do not have many takers. These little problems notwithstanding,

NGOs (and there are more than 100) on GiveIndia say that the concept of online donations was picking up, and they were glad they took the plunge.

Online giants, such as, Google and Rediff have given free ad space to GiveIndia. For instance, if you type in "India charity" on Google, the first sponsored link you get is the GiveIndia site, as part of the Google AdWords scheme.

Donors, too, have a good word to put in. Says Aarti Madhusudan, a UK-based Indian, in an e-mail to GiveIndia: "I am sure you hear this from many people and all the time, and it is probably superfluous, but I felt like saying that it is remarkable to set up something like GiveIndia, and I am honoured to be part of it, even if my donation is really small. I wish I could do more."

Swapnil and Tausef, just two of the hundreds of beneficiaries, are not really aware of who is donating online to fund them—be it Google or Aarti. But they couldn't care less—they just want to be a tailor and a pilot. And with it, give something back to the society that helped them. ■

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Tax Benefits

Section 80G of the Income Tax Act allows 50 per cent of your donation to be tax deductible. Impressed? There's more. Certain specified projects allow the benefit of Section 35AC of the IT Act that increases the percentage of deduction to 100 per cent. Section 35(i)(ii) goes further and shoots up the donation deductions to 125 per cent from your business income and 100 per cent from your salary income.